Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on William Shakespeare's "[When forty winters shall besiege thy brow]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's argument that the person being addressed in William Shakespeare's sonnet "[When forty winters shall besiege thy brow]" should have a child include

alliteration,
contrast,
controlling image,
iambic pentameter,
metaphor,
meter,
paradox,
parallelism,
rhetorical question (implied)
rhyme,
syncope (elision),
synecdoche,
theme,
tone,
visual imagery, and
volta.

The contestant might begin a discussion of this sonnet by examining the concluding couplet, which explains the thematic line 12.

The strength of the speaker's argument that the person being addressed should have a child (to be inferred as having a son) turns on the first line's synecdochical "forty winters," which connotes the ageing effects of having lived forty years and continues with the metaphorical "besiege[ing]," which suggests the turmoil of war, as well as the yearly trenching of the field (line 2), which comes to imply a unproductive effort toward procreation. Age and the attendant vicissitudes of life have reduced his beauty ("proud livery") to "tattered weed" (lines 3-4). The speaker has noted figuratively that his auditor's beauty, "the treasure of [his] lusty days" (lines 5-6) is gone.

The young LitCritter might note that the speaker offers something of challenge in asking whether additional praise could ensue were the once-beautiful forty-year-old man to be able to point to a now-beautiful son, a child to carry forward that beauty that had once brought so much praise.

The contestant might note that the speaker's logic finds strength in the inherent paradoxes of old being made new (line 13) and cold ensuring warm (line 14), both of which sum up the speaker's argument.

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An argument might be made that the subjunctive mood of line 8's "Were an all-eating shame . . . ." creates/constitutes a volta.